

Chapter 105-3

When leaving that shop, Xu Qingzhu's attitude toward the staff was even colder—it could even be called icy.

Liang Shi was silent for a moment but still asked: "Are you angry?"

"No," Xu Qingzhu said.

"Really?" Liang Shi pressed her lips together and said in a low voice: "But you don't look like you're not angry right now."

The atmosphere suddenly fell silent.

All around them were people coming and going. Occasionally, passersby would glance at the two of them but would just brush past.

The two stood not far from the mall entrance, eyes meeting.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu softened her voice and said: "I am angry."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi had no experience dealing with this kind of thing and didn't know what Xu Qingzhu was angry about.

She simply couldn't stand that cold atmosphere—it was so awkward—so she had taken the initiative to ask.

But after asking, then what?

She didn't know either.

So silence spread again. But the area around the mall was very noisy, with pedestrians constantly walking by. The road nearby was bustling with traffic—the sound of tires rolling over the ground. There was even an advertisement playing on loop at the top of the mall.

The advertisement featured Yang Shuyan's face, endorsing a skincare set.

Yang Shuyan's face displayed there was a powerful advertisement in itself.

The noise from the outside world made the silence between the two of them seem deathly still. Neither of them spoke.

Liang Shi felt an inexplicable nervousness. Her fingertips subconsciously rubbed against Xu Qingzhu's wrist, round and round.

It wasn't until Yang Shuyan's advertisement finished playing on the LED screen above the mall, changing to a popular star's music video.

As the restless intro music started, Xu Qingzhu finally spoke: "Why didn't you ask me what I'm angry about?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi's thoughts were in disarray. At this moment, she could only follow Xu Qingzhu's lead.

"Then what are you angry about?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu broke free from her hand, looking even angrier.

Liang Shi was somewhat dazed, suddenly becoming inarticulate.

Xu Qingzhu sniffled, and after a silence, asked her: "Do you have some task you have to complete?"

Liang Shi: "?"

In that instant, her pupils contracted. She was about to deny it when Xu Qingzhu said: "From initially not divorcing me, to wanting to come to the escape room with me—what exactly is driving you to do these things?"

Liang Shi froze.

But Xu Qingzhu's voice became even calmer: "This is your business. If you don't want to say, I won't ask. But you..."

Her voice choked up here, and tears glistened in her eyes, particularly dazzling under the refraction of the cold sunlight.

Liang Shi's heart suddenly ached terribly.

It was like biting into an unripe hawthorn berry—both sour and astringent.

Especially when, after her choked pause, Xu Qingzhu looked into her eyes and said: "Can you please be nicer to yourself?"

It was like this before, and it's still like this now.

Always thinking about how others are doing.

Clearly scared to death, yet still pushing forward.

Clearly feeling very low, yet forcing herself to tell bad jokes.

"Do you know your bad jokes aren't funny?" Now that she had opened up, Xu Qingzhu's words poured out like floodwaters through a broken dam. "The smile you force looks awful—just like the perfunctory smile I gave you earlier."

"Seeing you smile like that is like you seeing me smile like that." Xu Qingzhu's voice was cool, yet carried a somewhat low, hoarse quality.

When she spoke, it wasn't accusatory, but every word fell into Liang Shi's ears like cool spring water on a summer day, flowing through her limbs and body, leaving her completely at a loss.

Not knowing what to do.

Wanting so much to respond, yet not knowing how to respond.

Wanting to say something to her, wanting to instinctively deny it, yet unable to speak.

So afraid that saying anything would make Xu Qingzhu even angrier.

Making Xu Qingzhu angry didn't even seem like the scariest thing. What was scary was that Xu Qingzhu would feel sad, would be hurt.

Those beautiful eyes would shed tears.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together and raised her hand. Her slender arm wanted to reach over and wipe away the tears that were about to form in Xu Qingzhu's eyes, but Xu Qingzhu took half a step back, leaving her arm suspended in midair.

Only a few centimeters from Xu Qingzhu's face, yet it seemed so far away—too far to touch.

Xu Qingzhu exhaled lightly, readjusted her voice, and said to her coldly: "I'm not asking you to tell me anything, and I'm not asking you to do anything for me. Just be yourself properly, okay? Liang Shi."

When Xu Qingzhu's cool voice called out the two characters "Liang Shi," her voice fell with an indescribable tenderness.

Just like this morning in bed, when the drizzling rain was falling outside and there was only faint light inside the room.

Xu Qingzhu had called by her ear: "Teacher Liang."

When she called out faster, it became "Liang Shi."

Liang Shi's fingers curled and then uncurled.

The two people standing in place looked as beautiful as if they were shooting a pictorial. A withered yellow leaf from a nearby tree fell onto Liang Shi's shoulder, the branches now completely bare.

Xu Qingzhu glanced at it, took her hand out of her coat pocket, and quickly brushed the fallen leaf off her clothes.

Seeing that Liang Shi still had no reaction, her emotions became hard to contain, so she turned and walked forward.